

GENERAL INFORMATION ABOUT THE RESPONDANT:

- Country*:

Belgium

- Organization(s) or entity(s) responsible for the preparation of the report*:

Name:

Programmatory Federal Public Service for Science Policy (Belgian Science Policy Office or 'Belspo')

Website:

https://www.belspo.be/belspo/index_en.stm

Email address*:

www@belspo.be

Phone number*:

Please describe the role/mandate of your organization:

Federal government body responsible for research policy in Belgium. It designs and implements research programmes and networks and manages the participation of Belgium in European and international organisations. BELSPO supervises Belgian federal scientific organisations.

- Officially designated contact person(s) who completed this survey:

Full name*:

Marc Vanholsbeeck

Position*:

Head of the Direction Federal, Interfederal and International Coordination

Email address*:

- Full Name(s) of designated official(s) certifying the report:

Marc Vanholsbeeck, Eric Laureys, Annelies De wael, Ils De Bal, Philip Van Avermaet, Gaétan Du Roy

- Brief description of the consultation process established for the preparation of the report:

The survey was simultaneously submitted to the 5 public authorities, competent for science policy on both the federal and regional levels, to later be compiled by Belspo (there is no national Open Science policy in Belgium, but several regional ones). At Belspo, the OECD

Survey on National Contributions to EOSC 2023 was used as a basis. WEWIS also used the yearly reports provided by the Flemish research institutions in the context of the Flemish Open Science policy plan as a basis.

Those public authorities are:

BELSPO: Federal Science Policy Office

WEWIS: Departement Economie, Wetenschap en Innovatie tot het Departement Werk, Economie Wetenschap, Innovatie en Sociale Economie (WEWIS) (Flanders)

FWB: Fédération Wallonie-Bruxelles

Innoviris: Brussels-Capital Region

Wallonia : Service Publicpublic de Wallonie

- Other organization(s) or entit(y)(ies) (including non-governmental) consulted for completing this survey:

Name of the organization*:

Website*:

Email address*

Sector: ☐ Public ☐ Private ☐ Civil Society ☐ Other

B. QUESTIONNAIRE FOR MEMBER STATES' REPORTING ON THE IMPLEMENTATION OF THE 2021 RECOMMENDATION

1. PROMOTING A COMMON UNDERSTANDING OF OPEN SCIENCE, ASSOCIATED BENEFITS, AND CHALLENGES, AS WELL AS DIVERSE PATHS TO OPEN SCIENCE

- 1.1 Has the 2021 [Recommendation](#) been promoted and/or shared with appropriate ministries and institutions as well as affiliated organizations in your country?

YES / ~~NO~~

If yes, please indicate which ministries and or national authorities/entities have been involved in the promotion of the 2021 Recommendation.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPO

At Belspo, the Head of the [Direction Federal, Interfederal and International Coordination](#) was informed, as well as the 10 RPO's or [Federal Scientific Institutions \(FSI\)](#) funded by Belspo. The recommendation is mentioned on the [Belspo Open Science website](#).

WEWIS

The recommendation has been discussed with stakeholders in the Flemish Open Science Board at the time of its publication. Synergies of the Recommendation and European Open Science policy are especially relevant for us, and as such (part of) the content of the Recommendation is continuously promoted through our dedicated Open Science policy.

FWB

The recommendation is one of the most important reference texts that guide FW-B's efforts in the field of open science. Open science issues have been a priority for our administration for several years. The UNESCO recommendation is mentioned in our Open Science Road map (see below).

INNOVIRIS

The recommendation was not actively promoted or shared with the ministries but serves as a source document for developing and strengthening the encouragement policy around open science in the Brussels Capital Region.

- 1.2 Is the 2021 Recommendation on Open Science available in the national language(s) of your country?

~~YES~~ / NO

If **yes**, which language(s)?

Available in French, not available in Dutch and German.

- 1.3 Have there been awareness raising activities on open science, including all its key elementsⁱ, associated benefits and challenges, organized or foreseen to be organized by the end of 2025 in your country by national authorities or entities? (*ref.: (i) 16.f, 16.g, 16.h*)

YES / ~~NO~~

If **yes**, please provide details on the activities organized or foreseen and links as relevant.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPo

On 16/04/2024, under the auspices of the Belgian Presidency of the European Union, the Belgian Science Policy Office (Belspo), the Department of Science and Innovation of Flanders (EWI) and the Federation Wallonia-Brussels (FW-B) organized a National EOSC tripartite event in the Palais des Académies in Brussels. The goal of this event was to bring together the Belgian and European Open Science community and exchange best practices in the field of Open Science and Open Data. Participants were given the opportunity to present posters of ongoing projects and/or activities related to Open Science and integration in the European Open Science Cloud during a networking lunch.

<https://wayback.archive-it.org/12710/20240719013341/https://belgian-presidency.consilium.europa.eu/en/events/the-european-open-science-cloud-eosc-and-nationalregional-open-science-policy/>

WEWIS

In Flanders, all universities and most of the other research institutions organise events on Open Science focussing on awareness raising, training, collaboration, etc. on a regular (often at least yearly) basis.

The Flemish Open Science Board (FOSB) also actively brings together stakeholders to discuss benefits and challenges in Open Science.

Additionally, the Flemish Research Data Network is a network of RDM support officers (mostly, but not limited to, data stewards) of all Flemish research institutions which brings together stakeholders on a regular basis to work and discuss on very specific topics related to handling research data.

The FRDN also organises a network day, aimed at bringing together a wide range of stakeholders. On 11/05/2023, the Flemish Research Data Network (FRDN) organised a network day on Open Science for stakeholders. On 22/05/2025, the next FRDN network day for data stewards and the wider stakeholder community is planned.

<https://www.frdn.be/network-day-2023/>

<https://www.frdn.be/network-day-2025/>

A Belgian event on open access, predatory practices and copyright among stakeholders was organised by a group of stakeholders joined together in a collaboration called 'Open Access Belgium' on December 12, 2024. This facilitated sharing of knowledge and discussions on the challenges of open science among Belgian Open Science stakeholders.

FWB

In FW-B the Direction de la Recherche Scientifique adopted a roadmap for Open Science that was last revised in 2023. Among other things, it promotes the objective of "actively developing and maintaining an Open Science culture in the higher education institutions of the Wallonia-Brussels Federation, in collaboration with all the stakeholders involved and by ensuring that the existing tools already available are publicised." It promotes the idea of "supporting the deposit and sharing, via institutional directories, of publications intended for a wider audience and which contribute to the dissemination of knowledge in society."

Since 2021, the Data Ambassadors of the Fédération Wallonie Bruxelles have been organised as a network. The Data Ambassadors of the five universities of the FW-B form a collaborative network in which everyone can learn, be informed, be inspired and inspire their colleagues in terms of open and FAIR management of research data.

INNOVIRIS

The Brussels-Capital Region, through its agency Innoviris, has been stimulating Open Science mostly through the funding of the online open access journal Brussels Studies (OpenEdition journal) since 2006. After more than 1.5 million downloads (in 2021), it is a permanent free multilingual source of knowledge and territorial diagnostics for a wide audience. Link: <https://journals.openedition.org/brussels> . Researchers funded by Innoviris are formally encouraged to publish in Brussels Studies.

Brussels Studies is the key actor for awareness raising. It has been organizing events in collaboration with the Brussels Studies Institute, such as the Publish locally (and don't perish!) study afternoon in 2022 (as part of the Knowledge for the city festival). The main objective is addressing the fact that although the production of local knowledge is absolutely necessary for public action in Brussels and for the various social and urban actors in particular, the dissemination of that knowledge at local level is relatively little valorized in the academic sphere. Information on future events is currently unavailable.

- 1.4 Have specific actions been undertaken or are planned to be undertaken by end of 2025 in your country to incorporate the values and principles of open scienceⁱⁱ, in publicly funded research? (*ref.: (i) 16.a, 16.b, 16.c, 16.d, 16.e, 16.h*)

YES / ~~NO~~

If yes, please indicate the actions that are taken to incorporate the specific values and principles.

For each case, please provide details and links as relevant.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so?

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSP0

The issue of open science is included in several sections of the toolbox in the P4Science (Policy for Science) federal programme:

Knowledge hub: help Federal Scientific Institution to develop a knowledge hub to actively transfer knowledge and build capacity in their specific areas of expertise or missions, including in Open Science and Open Research Data. These gateways/platforms serve regulators and policy makers, facilitators, the community, direct visitors to the existing and emerging initiatives most suited to their needs, provide links to repositories, marketplaces, databases, projects, ...

Open science initiative: activities directed towards the spreading knowledge and data as soon as it is available using digital and collaborative technology, expert groups, publications, services, news, media, and events.

Training activity: support the training (opleiding) and further training (bijscholing) of the institution's research staff in the field of scientific research, proposal writing and career development, including in Open Science and Open Research Data.

Valorisation of administrative or scientific databases: financing of scientific activities linked to the valorisation of administrative or scientific databases. The aim is to support FSI in opening their data infrastructure and to comply with the FAIR principle (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable and Reusable).

Furthermore, any proposal submitted and funded must develop a detailed open and FAIR data management plan that includes:

- List of identifiers or repositories that will be used.
- Information on Open Access, as well as access provisions and IPR arrangement where relevant
- Provide information on standards, formats and vocabularies for data and metadata that will be used to make data interoperable.
- Licensing for data sharing and tools/software/models for data generation and validation/interpretation/re-use to ensure the re-usability of the data.

Open and FAIR compliance is a specific evaluation criterion for each proposal submitted.

WEWIS

In Flanders, the values and principles of Open Science are included in the Flemish Policy plan on Open Science 2019-2024 (extended with one year in 2025), which is the main source of public funding dedicated to Open Science.

Aside from the specific policy plan on Open Science, the values can also be found in the policy plan of the Flemish research funding agency FWO, available via the website: <https://www.fwo.be/media/5mthyvll/beleidsplan-2024-2028.pdf> (p.8)

All funding agreements of department WEWIS with research institutions also include requirements on Open Science.

FWB

- The FW-B passed a decree in 2018 requiring researchers working in HEIs to deposit their articles in institutional databases with open and full access. A new website has been launched in 2025 gathering the references from all university repositories. This portal is built up by harvesting, updated daily, the metadata of universities based on their own methods of feeding their institutional repositories. It therefore provides access to references to journal articles, books or parts of books, research or expert reports, doctoral theses, working papers, patents, teaching documents, documents from symposia, congresses and conferences, as well as general and popular communications published by members of the scientific community of the five French-speaking Belgian universities. www.periscops.be
The funding agency F.R.S.-FNRS has successfully reviewed and updated its open access policy in line of the FWB decree and the new federal copyright provisions.
Application of the decree is monitored by an ad hoc committee, which publishes an annual report.
All 5 FW-B universities have signed the Coara agreement which promotes among others to take into account the open access practices in research evaluation.

INNOVIRIS

Innoviris will implement its open access publication encouragement policy in 2025 and publish it on its website. It is based on FAIR principles, encourages green open access, and includes an open data policy through DMP.

2. DEVELOPING AN ENABLING POLICY ENVIRONMENT FOR OPEN SCIENCE

2.1 Does your country have a national policyⁱⁱⁱ, strategy or plan of action on science, technology and innovation (STI)?

YES / ~~NO~~

If yes

- please attach/upload a machine-readable PDF file of the policy and provide the following information: Title of the policy, the authority in charge of development of the policy, entities involved and the process of development, year of adoption, year of last update, key areas/sections of the policy, and links to the webpage if available.
- does it include any of the following open science elements:
 - open access to scientific knowledge
 - open science infrastructure
 - open engagement of societal actors
 - open dialogue with other knowledge systems

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPo

Belgium is a federation of several entities, federal and regional, which share science policy competences. 'National policy', one might state, unfolds within a national consulting body named 'International Co-operation Commission and Federal Co-operation Commission' (ICC-FCC). Thematic subcommissions focus on particular science policy topics. One such thematic subcommission is competent for Open Science and will be UNESCO's official Belgian partner for this survey. Please note that the Belgian federal authority has no precedence over regional authorities. They are equal consulting partners. As such, several strategic policies will be described hereunder.

The Federal authority: Belspo

- Title of the policy: 'Management Agreement 2022-2024'
- Authority in charge of development of the policy: Belspo, and therefore the federal Secretary of State in charge of Science Policy, attached to the federal Minister of Economy and Employment.
- Entities involved and the process of development:
- Belspo's Federal, Interfederal and International Coordination Direction
- Belnet,
- the national research and education network
- 10 federal RPO's named 'Federal Scientific Institutions' (FSI)
- Year of adoption: 2022
- Year of last update: update foreseen in 2025
- Key areas/sections of the policy: item 13.2
- Link to the webpage:
https://www.belspo.be/belspo/organisation/about/doc/2022_2024_PlanStrat_fr.pdf

The federal authority is engaged in Open Access to scientific knowledge, Open Science infrastructure (EOSC) and Open Data. In the strategic plan of BELSPO (2022-2024), there is a firm commitment to the open data and open science strategy, in order to facilitate access to information and science, and to encourage the re-use of research data produced by our researchers (FAIR data) and to strengthen our key collaborations. Furthermore, the strategic plan of BELSPO (2022-2024) considers the citizens as important stakeholders, notably in the context of their engagement with the federal scientific institutions in the context of citizen science and outreach activities.

Furthermore a Federal Open Science Strategy Committee (FOSSC) has been established in 2024 in order to provide the board of directors of BELSPO with strategic piece of advice regarding Open Science policies at federal level.

WEWIS

Flanders: WEWIS

- Title of the policy: Science & Innovation Decree
- Authority in charge of development of the policy: department of Work, Economy, Science, Innovation and Social Economy of the Government of Flanders (WEWIS)
- Entities involved and the process of development:
- Year of adoption: 2009
- Year of last update: 2023
- Key areas/sections of the policy: This is the main decree that provides the legal framework for specific policies and funding agreements. The section on Open Science can be found under article 2/3.
- Links to the webpage:
<https://codex.vlaanderen.be/Portals/Codex/documenten/1018085.html>

And based on this decree, specific policy plans on Open Science and on Science Communication (including Citizen Science) have been drawn up, which include these open science elements.

FWB

The FW-B policy is expressed in the Open Science Road Map which is not yet a public document. This policy is discussed by a group of experts who meet at regular intervals to monitor open science issues and make proposals.

INNOVIRIS

One of the strategic innovation domains from the Smart Specialisation Strategy and the Regional Innovation Plan 21-27, adopted by the Government in 2021 (<https://www.innoviris.brussels/regional-innovation-plan>) is social innovation, public innovation and social inclusion. This includes strengthening knowledge dissemination tools and includes the implementation and encouragement of open science practices. Through this, the Region particularly aims to strengthen the link between science and society, a major challenge for Brussels. The ambition for 27 covers open access to scientific knowledge, open engagement of societal actors and open dialogue with other knowledge systems, but also strengthening open science infrastructures.

- 2.2 In your country, is there a policy, or a set of policies and/or legal framework(s)^{iv} at the national level that address open science or any of its key elements in line with the definition, values and principles outlined in the 2021 Recommendation on Open Science? (*ref.: (i) 16.a, 16.b, 16.c, 16.d, 16.e, 16.h*)

YES / PARTLY / NO

If yes or partly, please attach/upload machine-readable PDF file(s) of the policy(ies) and provide the following information for each: *Title of the policy or legal instrument, the authority in charge of development of the policy, entities involved and the process of development, year of adoption, year of last update, key areas/sections of the policy, elements of open science that are addressed, and links to the webpage(s) if available.*

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to develop such policies.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPo

Policy instrument: Belspo Management Agreement

- Entities involved and the process of development: Belspo
- Year of adoption: 2022
- Key areas/sections of the policy: item 13.2
- Elements of open science: A commitment to an open data and open science strategy; facilitate access to information and science, stimulate the reuse of research data produced by researchers (FAIR data), strengthen key collaborations. Implementation priorities: The European 'Open data' directive, which applies to both Research Data and scientific publications, mentioned as applicable as of 2023; The EOSC (European Open Science Cloud), a European partnership; The refocusing of the national research and education network ([BELNET](https://www.belnet.be/)) on supporting research, by including horizontal tools in support of Open science in its product catalog.
- Link to the webpage:
https://www.belspo.be/belspo/organisation/about_managAgree_en.stm

Policy instrument: Open Access mandate

- Entities involved and the process of development: Belspo
- Year of adoption: 2017
- Key areas/sections of the policy: p. 3-4
- Elements of open science: Open Access to publications
- Link to the webpage:
https://www.belspo.be/belspo/openscience/mandate_en.stm
- Policy instrument: Open Research Data mandate
- Entities involved and the process of development:
- Year of adoption: 2019
- Year of last update: 2020
- Key areas/sections of the policy: p. 1-2
- Elements of open science: Open Access to Research Data
- Link to the webpage: https://www.belspo.be/belspo/openscience/mandate_en.stm

Legal instrument (National law): Secondary Publishing Right (SPR)

- Entities involved and the process of development: Flemish University and Higher Education Council (VLUHR); Ministry of Finance, Budget and Energy; Flemish Interuniversity Council (VLIR); Representation of the Universities; Council of Rectors (CRef); Ministry of Development Cooperation, Digital Agenda, Telecom and Postal Services; Representation of the Publishers; Intellectual Property Council
- Year of adoption: 2017
- Key areas/sections of the policy: Art. 29
- Elements of open science: Deposit in Open Access Repositories
- Link to the webpage:

http://www.ejustice.just.fgov.be/cgi/article.pl?language=fr&sum_date=2018-09-05&lg_txt=f&pd_search=2018-09-05&s_editie=&numac_search=2018031589&caller=&2018031589=&view_numac=2018031589nl

WEWIS

- Title of the policy: Flemish Open Science policy plan (2019-2024, extended by 1 year in 2025)
 - Authority in charge of development of the policy: department of Work, Economy, Science, Innovation and Social Economy of the Government of Flanders (WEWIS)
 - Entities involved and the process of development:
 - All 36 research institutions in Flanders
 - FWO (Flemish research funding agency)
 - VLAIO (Flemish innovation funding agency)
 - Year of adoption: 2019
 - Year of last update: 2025
 - Key areas/sections of the policy: The policy plan is dedicated to Open Science in its entirety
 - Links to the webpage: <https://www.ewi-vlaanderen.be/nieuws/vlaamse-beleidsplan-open-science-en-oprichting-open-science-board-goedgekeurd>
-
- Title of the policy: Flemish Science Communication policy plan (2022-2030)
 - Authority in charge of development of the policy: department of Work, Economy, Science, Innovation and Social Economy of the Government of Flanders (WEWIS)
 - Entities involved and the process of development:
 - Structural science communication actors (listed in the document) in Flanders
 - FWO (Flemish research funding agency)
 - VLAIO (Flemish innovation funding agency)
 - Year of adoption: 2022
 - Year of last update: /
 - Key areas/sections of the policy: p.8-9, RVO society vzw – umbrella organisation for Brightlab and Scivil
 - Links to the webpage: <https://www.ewi-vlaanderen.be/onze-opdracht/innoverende-samenleving/wetenschapscommunicatie#toc-beleidsplan-wetenschapscommunicatie>

There are several KPI's that have been co-created with stakeholders to monitor the progress of OS at the Flemish research institutions, regarding open data, open access, FAIR, DMP, ORCID iD.

The policy plan – with funds and through discussions in the FOSB and its working groups – also deals with open science infrastructure.

Open engagement of societal actors is encompassed within the Flemish policy plan on science communication. Specifically, Scivil is the Flemish knowledge center on citizen science.

At the very start of the policy plan on Open Science (end of 2019, early 2020), industrial representatives were involved in the discussions at the Flemish Open Science Board (FOSB). However, it has proven very difficult to keep industry actively involved in the discussions. In view of the next policy period, new discussions on how to involve industry will be set up.

FWB

A decree has been adopted in 2018. Its aim is “to promote the open access dissemination of the results of research financed by public subsidies emanating in whole or in part from the French Community to enable the free circulation of knowledge and thus innovation

innovation ; to enable everyone, regardless of the means at their disposal, access to scientific documentation produced by researchers; to increase the visibility of researchers and their work; to strengthen research carried out in the French Community by giving it visibility and promote the social extension of what is discovered or invented or invented with public funding provided in whole or in part by the French partially from the French Community.” The decree requires researchers “to deposit in an institutional digital archive all their publications resulting from research carried out in whole or in part with public funds originating in whole or in part from the French Community, in extenso, immediately after acceptance of the article by a publisher.” A report on the effects of the decree is published each year by an ARES (Académie de Recherche et d’Enseignement Supérieur) committee. <https://www.ares-ac.be/fr/actualites/937-decret-open-access-rapport-2022>

INNOVIRIS

Open Science engagements are embedded in the Regional Innovation Plan and Smart Specialisation Strategy 21-27. Nevertheless, no legal framework exists for open science, related to the competences of the Brussels Capital Region.

2.3 In your country, are there specific policy instruments^v that aim to promote open science?

YES/ UNDER DEVELOPMENT/NO

If yes or under development, please provide details and links as relevant, including for each instrument: Title of the instrument, its objective, the authority in charge, allocated budget, elements of open science included.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to develop such policy instruments.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPO

Title of the instrument: [Research Contracts](#)

Objective: Furthering implementation of deposit of publications in Open Access repositories

Authority in charge: Direction [Research Programmes](#), Belspo

Allocated budget: N/A

Elements of open science included: Open Access to publications

Title of the instrument: Open Science [Helpdesk](#)

Objective: Inform, help, solve problems.

Authority in charge: Direction [Federal, Interfederal and International Coordination](#), Belspo

Allocated budget: None

Elements of open science included: Any

Furthermore a Federal Open Science Strategy Committee (FOSSC) has been established in 2024 in order to provide the board of directors of BELSPO with strategic piece of advice regarding Open Science policies at federal level.

WEWIS

The policy plan on Open Science, with dedicated funding.

The requirement to enter data into our FRIS information platform included in all funding agreements with individual institutions.

The obligation to publish in open access in the FWO (Flemish funding agency) funding agreements for researchers.

FWB

At the level of the FW-B administration we have set up a contact group to monitor the ERA's work on open science policies which has established a roadmap which is not public. There is no specific budget allocated to it.

However, different projects were funded by FW-B to support activities related to open science. The Open Access decree and its follow-up are also policy instruments to encourage open access practices.

INNOVIRIS

Brussels Studies Journal (OpenEdition).

Funded by the Brussels Capital Region (2023-2027): 950.000 EUR

Objective: bring the results of scientific research into the public debate and to strengthen the link between science and society by presenting an effective tool for disseminating knowledge, in line with one of the objectives of the strategic innovation domain 'Science & Society: participatory and inclusive approaches' of the Regional Innovation Plan 2021-2027.

The Brussels Studies Institute (BSI), funded by the Brussels Capital Region, and the Brussels Information, Documentation and Research Centre (BRIO) also work closely together to promote and disseminate scientific research on Brussels. Founded in 2005, BRIO focuses on increasing knowledge about Brussels and its surrounding municipalities through interdisciplinary and policy-oriented research. It acts as a virtual information and documentation centre, providing a comprehensive database of scientific publications, policy information and statistics on Brussels.

Funded by the Brussels Capital Region (22-24) - Brussels Studies Institute: 810.000 EUR

- 2.4 In your country, is there a national implementation plan, strategy, policy or a roadmap for implementation of open science at the national level in line with the 2021 Recommendation? (ref.: [\(ii\) 17.a, 17.b, 17.c, 17.f, 17.h](#))

YES / ~~UNDER DEVELOPMENT~~ / NO

If yes or under development, please provide details and links as relevant, including the name of ministries and national authorities/entities, as well as affiliated organizations that are involved in the development and implementation of the plan, strategy or the roadmap.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to develop such policy instruments.

Individual responses of different policy levels

WEWIS

Flanders: policy plan on Open Science since 2019, with adaptations along the way in co-creation with stakeholders, also in line with evolutions at European and UNESCO level.

- Title of the policy: Flemish Open Science policy plan (2019-2024, extended by 1 year in 2025)
- Authority in charge of development of the policy: department of Work, Economy, Science, Innovation and Social Economy of the Government of Flanders (WEWIS)
- Entities involved and the process of development:
 - All 36 research institutions in Flanders
 - FWO (Flemish research funding agency)
 - VLAIO (Flemish innovation funding agency)
- Year of adoption: 2019
- Year of last update: 2025
- Key areas/sections of the policy: The policy plan is dedicated to Open Science in its entirety

- Links to the webpage: <https://www.ewi-vlaanderen.be/nieuws/vlaamse-beleidsplan-open-science-en-oprichting-open-science-board-goedgekeurd>

FWB

Yes the roadmap has already been mentioned.

- 2.5 In your country, are there policies and/or strategies that promote open science in line with the 2021 Recommendation at **institutional** level, including in the context of research-performing institutions, universities, scientific unions and associations and learned societies? (ref.: (ii) 17.d, 17.e, 17.g)

YES /~~UNDER DEVELOPMENT~~/ NO

If **yes**, please provide more information, including the number of policies, name of the institute(s) that has/have developed the policy(s) and [elements of open science](#), included in the policy (please consider policies and strategies addressing all elements of open science, including citizen and participatory science, or co-production of knowledge with multiple actors).

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSP0

there are no specific Open Science policies at the level of the Federal Scientific Institutions. There is an Open Access and an Open Data mandate at federal level, to which any research funded by the federal government must comply.

WEWIS

Yes, many of the 36 Flemish research institutions have developed an internal open science policy plan over the last few years, stimulated by the Flemish Open Science policy plan and the yearly reporting linked to that. Policies cover aspects such as Open Access, requirements linked to institutional repositories, RDM, etc.

Some examples (non-exhaustive overview):

- <https://www.ugent.be/en/research/openscience>
- <https://www.kuleuven.be/open-science/open-science-at-ku-leuven>
- <https://www.uantwerpen.be/en/research/policy/open-science/>
- <https://www.vub.be/nl/ons-onderzoek/onze-visie-en-missie/optimale-onderzoeksomgeving/data-management-open-science#:~:text=Dit%20verwijst%20naar%20het%20verlenen,is%20via%20de%20PURE%20interface.>
- <https://www.uhasselt.be/en/research/research-management-data-analysis/open-science#anch-15b-open-science-practices-at-hasselt-university>
- Universities of applied sciences and arts in the AUGent are developing specific open science policies as well
- <https://www.vlaanderen.be/inbo/onderzoeksdomeinen/data-infrastructuur/open-data-en-open-science/>

FWB

The FW-B roadmap covers open science in general but the legislative efforts focus so far on the open access aspect of it.

Most FW-B universities have developed their own open science policies and offer training to raise awareness among PhD candidates and postdocs.

- 2.6 In your country, are there specific funding mechanisms^{vi} for open science at the national level? (ref.: [\(ii\) 17.i](#), [\(iii\) 18.i](#), [\(iv\) 19.c](#))

YES / ~~UNDER DEVELOPMENT~~ / NO

If **yes or under development**, please provide details and links as relevant.

If **no**, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to develop such funding mechanisms.

Individual responses of different policy levels

WEWIS

Linked to the policy plan on Open Science, there is a budget of 5 million euros that is distributed over 36 research institutions that can be used for infrastructure and data stewards/IT personnel.

Researchers can also submit expenses for gold open access publications via FWO in the context of their research projects.

FWB

No.

- 2.7 In your country, have open science practices^{vii} been integrated in existing research funding mechanisms?

YES / ~~NO~~

If **yes**, please provide details and links as relevant.

If **no**, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSP0

See 2.3 : The Federal authority: Title of the instrument: Research Contracts

WEWIS

Yes, FWO and VLAIO funding instruments include Open Science requirements. So do all the institution-specific funding agreements that WEWIS has with the Flemish research institutions.

FWB

The Board of Trustees of the F.R.S.-FNRS (our funding agency) has approved the initiative consisting of valorising the researchers' open science practices in the frame of its evaluation procedures.

INNOVIRIS

Currently only a limited number of RDI funding programmes in the Brussels-Capital Region include open science requirements. In 2025 a generalized policy will be put in place.

- 2.8 Have efforts been made or are foreseen to be undertaken by end of 2025 in your country to foster equitable public-private partnerships on open science in line with the 2021 Recommendation? (ref.: [\(ii\) 17.i](#))

NO

If **yes**, please provide details and links as relevant.

If **no**, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

No. Until today, the federal OS policies only concern our (public) research institutions.

- 2.9 Is there a national monitoring framework for open science in your country? Or are there specific indicators on open science included in the national monitoring and evaluation framework for STI policy (ref.: [\(ii\) 17.j, 23.c](#))

YES / ~~UNDER DEVELOPMENT~~ / NO

If **yes or under development**, please provide details and links as relevant.

Individual responses of different policy levels

WEWIS

Open Science monitoring in Flanders is performed via the yearly reports included in the Open Science policy plan. As such, some KPI's (ORCID ID, DMP, Open Access, Open Data) are quantitatively monitored. Other relevant aspects are also reported qualitatively, such as the actions concerning institutional Open Science policies etc.

The Flemish Research Information Space (FRIS) is an important aspect of this monitoring procedure, as it allows us to a large extent to automate the monitoring of the KPI's..

As Open Science is included in all dedicated funding agreements with research institutions, it also is part of the recurring evaluation of these institutions, in cycles of 5 year, as a basis for renewing the institutional funding agreements.

FWB

An annual report follows-up the effect and application of the Open Acces decree.

PeriscOApe, is a pilot tool developed by ULiège, which has been designed to meet the need to monitor and observe Open Access (OA) in the Wallonia-Brussels Federation (FWB).

PeriscOApe aims to determine the proportion of the institution's scientific articles available in Open Access in various forms and to show their evolution over time, by subject, by publisher, and by specifying the number of articles that have or have not required the payment of APCs (article processing charges). PeriscOApe is fully in line with UNESCO's recommendations for Open Science and with the logic of evaluating the effects of the Wallonia-Brussels Federation's Open Access Decree. The PeriscOApe project was funded by Bibliothèque Interuniversitaire de la Communauté française de Belgique (BICfB).
<https://lib.uliege.be/fr/open-science/nos-outils/periscoape>

3. INVESTING IN OPEN SCIENCE INFRASTRUCTURES AND SERVICES

- 3.1 What is the latest official data for your country's percentage of national gross domestic product (GDP) dedicated to research and development expenditure? Please also indicate the year of publication of this data, and to which year(s) it refers. (ref.: [\(iii\) 18.a](#))

3.39%: published in 2025 and referring to 2021. In June 2025, final data will be published for 2022 and 2023.

- 3.2 What is the latest official data for the percentage of your country's population that have access to reliable internet and bandwidth? Please also indicate the year of publication of this data, and to which year(s) it refers. (ref.: [\(iii\) 18.b](#))

95.9 % 16-74 year old vs. 59.6 % 75-89 year old (source: Statbel). Published in 2024 and referring to 2024.

- 3.3 Are there national research and education networks (NRENs)^{viii} active in the country? (ref.: [\(iii\) 18.c](#))

YES / NO

If yes, please provide more information and links as relevant, and indicate to which open science actors in your country those networks are accessible.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to establish them.

The Belgian NREN is [Belnet](#). Belnet caters to all educational and academic organizations, and science policy administrations in Belgium, including regional ones.

- 3.4 Are there national or institutional [open science infrastructures](#)^{ix} in your country? (ref.: [\(iii\) 18.d, 18.e, 18.k, 18.l, 18.m](#))

YES / UNDER DEVELOPMENT / ~~NO~~

If yes or under development, please indicate which type(s) of infrastructure:

- federated information technology infrastructure for open science, including high-performance computing, cloud computing and data storage.
- community managed infrastructures, protocols and standards, for example those that support bibliodiversity and engagement with society
- platforms for exchanges and co-creation of knowledge between scientists and society
- community-based monitoring and information systems to complement national, regional and global data and information systems.

For each infrastructure, please provide links as relevant and more information with regard to their compliance with the 2021 Recommendation on Open Science in terms of inclusivity, accessibility, interoperability, community governance, FAIR (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable) and CARE (Collective Benefit, Authority to Control, Responsibility and Ethics) principles. Please indicate if the infrastructure is non-commercial.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPo

Community managed infrastructures, protocols and standards:

[DMP Online](#) is a national bottom-up initiative, a tool to help researchers of several universities and RPOs generate and manage Data Management Plans. It is administrated by a consortium and hosted by the NREN Belnet.

Platforms for exchanges and co-creation of knowledge between scientists and society:

[Orfeo](#) is the Federal Repository for Open Access to publications. It is a centralized 'orphan' repository, mainly targeted at the [10 FS](#) but is open to all public partners in Belgium. It is administrated by Belso and hosted by the NREN Belnet.

BELSPO Citizen science platform. Following **Federal Mutual Learning Event** organized by Royal Belgian Institute of Natural Sciences & Royal Museum for Central Africa with different Federal Stakeholders (BELSPO + Federal Scientific Institutions) participating (January 2023) *and* **European Mutual Learning Exercise on Citizen Science at the** Royal Belgian Institute of Natural Sciences (January 2023), BELSPO has developed and published an information and knowledge sharing platform for the Citizen Science-projects of the Federal Scientific Institutes. The goal of the platform is to integrate the public as stakeholders in the research and development activities of the Federal Scientific Institutions. https://www.belspo.be/belspo/CitizenScience/index_en.stm

SODHA is a data archive for social sciences and digital humanities in Belgium as well as a service provider that represents Belgium in the Consortium of European Social Science Data Archives (CESSDA). The aim of SODHA is to ensure the **conservation** of research data produced by social sciences and digital humanities and to enable their **reuse**. Researchers can **deposit** their datasets, which will be **preserved** in the long term and receive a **DOI**, making them citable like publications. Thanks to the search engine of the Dataverse software, researchers can **search the collections** of SODHA and find documented datasets ready for reuse.

WEWIS

Non-exhaustive overview:

- FRIS | [Research Portal](#)
 - FRIS also provides an overview of "e-Resources" that are relevant for this question:
https://researchportal.be/nl/search?f%5B0%5D=fris_content_type%3Ainfrastruct&f%5B1%5D=fris_infrastructure_type%3AE-resource&search_api_fulltext=&items_per_page=50&sort=search_api_relevance&order=desc#pagetitle
- KU Leuven RDR <https://www.kuleuven.be/rdm/en/rdr>
- KU Leuven Lirias <https://research.kuleuven.be/en/lirias>
- UHasselt Document Server <https://documentserver.uhasselt.be/>
- UAntwerpen repository <https://repository.uantwerpen.be/desktop/irua>
- UGent Biblio <https://biblio.ugent.be/>
- VUB VUBIR <https://biblio.vub.ac.be/iguana/www.main.cls?p=e0de136e-cba4-11e8-a223-005056b658d1&language=eng&v=a079b3e4-cba6-11e8-9d3e-005056b658d1&CSPCHD=00d002000000qd4rLppQifiTrLZiAPYxl5nDnDroMI9RicOEgi>
- FAIRvault (VUB, UHasselt, UGent, UAntwerpen) – still under development
<https://osf.io/yv2mw/>
- Universities of applied sciences and arts DOSP:
<https://www.vlaamsehogescholelenraad.be/nl/dosp>
- VSC <https://www.vscentrum.be/>
- CRIS systems at other research institutions, such as (but not limited to) ILVO and KMDA-CRC
- VLIZ, KMDA, INBO, APM : <https://www.dissco.eu/be/>

FWB

PeriScops (www.periscops.be): All universities have their repositories and there is new a database giving access to all publications stored in those databases

Refer (<https://recherches.cfwb.be/>) : The RéFéR directory gives everyone access to publications (presentations, reports, articles, etc.) resulting from research produced, co-produced, financed or co-financed by the Ministry in each of its areas of competence.

Reliade (<https://reliade.be/>) is the French-speaking Belgian network (launched in 2024) of open access journals. It brings together journals, libraries and university presses. Its aim is to pool their practical knowledge and experience in order to support a fairer publishing model. It facilitates discussion of issues related to the scientific publishing ecosystem and relays the interests of open access scientific journals to institutions and research funding bodies.

INNOVIRIS

Brussels Studies: <https://journals.openedition.org/brussels/?lang=en>

BRIO – Centre for Information, Documentation and Research on Brussels: <https://www.briobrusssel.be/?language=en>

3.5 Does your country host or fund any federated regional or international information technology infrastructure for open science? (*ref.: (iii) 18.e, 18.f*)

YES / NO

If yes, please provide links as relevant and more information, including the name of the infrastructure, date of establishment, language, target groups and beneficiaries, governance/community agreements, scope (e.g. research areas, elements of open scienceⁱ, stage of research, accessibility to all the relevant users in the region or internationally).

If no, are the existing open science infrastructures at regional and international levels accessible to all the relevant open science actors from your country?

YES / NO

Individual responses of different policy levels

WEWIS

FRIS (researchportal.org)

- Date of establishment: 2006
- Language: Dutch & English
- Target groups and beneficiaries: researchers, policymakers, companies, research funders, research institutes, citizens
- Governance/community agreements: decree for science and innovation, government decrees, bilateral agreements with research institutes
- Scope: all (partly) publicly funded research performed in Flanders

INNOVIRIS

Brussels Studies Journal (OpenEdition).

Funded by the Brussels Capital Region (2023-2027): 950.000 EUR

Objective: bring the results of scientific research into the public debate and to strengthen the link between science and society by presenting an effective tool for disseminating knowledge, in line with one of the objectives of the strategic innovation domain 'Science & Society: participatory and inclusive approaches' of the Regional Innovation Plan 2021-2027.

BRIO - The Brussels Studies Institute (BSI), funded by the Brussels Capital Region, and the Brussels Information, Documentation and Research Centre (BRIO) also work closely together to promote and disseminate scientific research on Brussels. Founded in 2005, BRIO focuses on increasing knowledge about Brussels and its surrounding municipalities through interdisciplinary and policy-oriented research. It acts as a virtual information and documentation centre, providing a comprehensive database of scientific publications, policy information and statistics on Brussels.

Funded by the Brussels Capital Region (22-24) - Brussels Studies Institute: 810.000 EUR

- 3.6 Is your country involved in any North-South, North-South-South and South-South collaborations to optimize infrastructure use and joint strategies for shared, multinational, regional and national open science platforms? (ref.: [\(iii\) 18.g](#))

~~YES~~ / NO

If **yes**, please provide links as relevant and more information, including the name of the infrastructure, date of establishment, language, target groups and beneficiaries, governance/community agreements, scope (e.g. research areas, elements of open scienceⁱ, stage of research, accessibility to all the relevant users in the region or internationally).

Individual responses of different policy levels

WEWIS

The Plantentuin Meise is actively supporting the Global Biodiversity Information Facility (GBIF) <https://www.gbif.org/>

4. INVESTING IN HUMAN RESOURCES, TRAINING, EDUCATION, DIGITAL LITERACY AND CAPACITY BUILDING FOR OPEN SCIENCE

- 4.1 Has systematic capacity building on open science taken place in higher education and/or research performing institutions in your country? (ref.: [\(iv\) 19.a, 19.c](#))

YES / NO

If **yes**, please indicate if those capacity building initiatives are formal or informal and provide more information and links as relevant.

If **no**, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPO

Yes. [FedOSC](#) is a federal initiative to promote [Open Science](#) and [FAIR data practices](#) within the Belgian federal scientific community. Launched on April 1, 2024, the project aims to transform the landscape of scientific research at the federal level.

FedOSC will work on creating a comprehensive policy framework to guide [Open Science](#) practices across [Federal Scientific Institutions](#) (FSIs). This will ensure a consistent approach to data sharing, open access publishing, and research transparency.

FedOSC aims to align Belgian federal research infrastructure with the broader European Open Science ecosystem. Readiness for future [EOSC](#) integration will enable seamless data exchange and collaboration with European partners.

The project will focus on developing and improving digital infrastructure and tools essential for Open Science. This includes enhancing existing platforms and creating new ones to support data management, sharing, and collaboration.

The project will produce an inventory of the existing research data in the federal institutes, provide guidance, training, and resources to help FSIs develop and implement their own Open Science strategies, tailored to their specific needs and research domains.

WEWIS

Yes, both aimed at researchers, as well as aimed at data stewards/RDM support staff. Through the funding linked to the Open Science policy plan in Flanders, data stewards are employed at the institutions. Through the Flemish Research Data Network (FRDN), they actively engage in knowledge exchange.

Within the institutions, data stewards and RDM support staff organise training for researchers dedicated to Open Science practices.

Most of the Flemish research institutions also organise their own specific events around Open Science to increase awareness and capabilities among researchers.

FWB

There is a network of data stewards since 2022 called “data ambassadors” in all 5 FW-B universities.

https://orbi.uliege.be/bitstream/2268/292039/1/20220531_RapportRDMFWB_SCI_v4.pdf

Suitable training courses are available at universities.

- 4.2 Have capacity building programmes for policy makers on how to integrate [core values](#) and [principles](#) of open science in STI policies and strategies taken place in your country?

~~YES~~ / NO

If **yes**, please provide more information and links as relevant.

If **no**, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

No.

- 4.3 Has a framework of open science competencies been incorporated into higher education research skills curricula in your country, or is it foreseen by the end of 2025? (ref.: [\(iv\) 19.b](#))

YES / ~~NO~~

If **yes**, please provide more information and links as relevant.

If **no**, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSP0

In the framework of the [FedOSC](#) initiative, various training opportunities will be offered in the course of 2025 to help researchers develop their skills in data management, open publishing, and other aspects of Open Science.

WEWIS

Doctoral schools offer training related to Open Science, as a part of the basic skillset for young researchers.

The data stewards of the various research institutions offer trainings and guidance to all researchers, often in a needs-based approach.

FWB

Suitable training courses are available for young researchers.

- 4.4 Are open educational resources^x as defined in the [2019 Recommendation on Open Educational Resources](#), used as an instrument for open science capacity building in your country in line with the 2019 Recommendation mentioned above? (ref.: [\(iv\) 19.d](#))

~~YES~~/PARTLY/~~NO~~

Individual responses of different policy levels

WEWIS

In the context of the Flemish Research Data Network, institutions share best practices and teaching materials on how to train researchers. Many institutions have openly available training packages.

There is even a game that is being co-developed among the FRDN members to get researchers engaged with Open Science in an interactive manner. This initiative is building on the game developed by the KU Leuven “Research Survival Game”: <https://bib.kuleuven.be/onderzoek/researchsurvivalgame>

FWB

A game designed to test and deepen knowledge about open science has been developed at ULiège. Its name is OpenScientoMètre : <https://lib.uliege.be/fr/open-science/nos-outils/openscientometre>

- 4.5 Have there been any initiatives in your country to support science communication in line with open science value and principles with a view to the dissemination of scientific knowledge to researchers of different disciplines, decision-makers and the public at large? (ref.: [\(iv\) 19.e](#))

YES / ~~NO~~

If yes, please provide more information and links as relevant.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPo

See 1.3.

The [Belgian Biodiversity Platform](#) is a [Belgian Science Policy Office](#) (Belspo) funded initiative that works in cooperation with policy and research institutions; a neutral and interest-free

science-policy interface, providing credible information on biodiversity science; and a major actor in national, European, international and intergovernmental biodiversity initiatives.

The Belgian Biodiversity Platform is a science-policy interface that offers a privileged and open access to primary biodiversity data and research information. The Platform encourages interdisciplinary cooperation among scientists and serves as an interface between researchers and science-policy organizations. It provides advice on the designation of biodiversity research priorities and promotes Belgian biodiversity research in international fora.

Open and free access to reliable biodiversity knowledge and data is key in responding to the challenges facing decision-making in terms of biodiversity. Extending the principles of openness to the whole research process entails a systemic change to the way science is done and used in practice, supporting mandatory scientific integrity.

WEWIS

In Flanders, there is a dedicated Science Communication policy plan. Various science communication actors are supported, among others the Flemish knowledge center on citizen science, Scivil.

Furthermore, the Flemish research funding agency FWO has adopted the requirement that researchers should publish a popularizing text, in Dutch, on the findings of their research project, as a condition for receiving the funding.

Many other science communication initiatives arise from the institutions themselves, taking up an active role in communicating on research to the general public, and to policymakers via science advice.

5. FOSTERING A CULTURE OF OPEN SCIENCE AND ALIGNING INCENTIVES FOR OPEN SCIENCE

5.1 Have there been any initiatives at the national or institutional level, e.g. by universities and/or research performing institutions, to review the existing research assessment and evaluation processes in order to align them with open science principles and values or are they foreseen by the end of 2025? (*ref.: (v) 20.b, 20c, 20i*)

YES / ~~NO~~

If yes, please provide more information and links as relevant.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPO

Yes. According to [BELSPO Open Access to publication mandate](#): “In order to be taken into account for researchers’ evaluations, career advancement, internal job applications or BELSPO research project funding, research results covered by this mandate and covered by this mandate only will have to be deposited (access to the content is optional) in the applicants’ research organisation’s institutional OA repository or in Orfeo [BELSPO repository]”

WEWIS

Yes. The governance of the Open Science policy plan in Flanders entails several thematic working groups and project groups. Recently, the project group “Enriching Research Assessment with Open Science Practices” concluded its work, by formulating concrete recommendations, approved by all stakeholders via the Flemish Open Science Board

(FOSB). Concrete steps are now taken to further include aspects of Open Science, Open Data and FAIR in the assessment of research projects by FWO. Efforts spent by researchers on Open Science can be reported to FWO already for some time, among other non-classically academic output/efforts, in line with the evolutions of CoARA at international/European level.

FWB

The Board of Trustees of the F.R.S.-FNRS has approved the initiative consisting of valorizing the researchers' open science practices in the frame of its evaluation procedures.

- 5.2 Have specific clauses that recognize open science practices, including sharing, collaborating and engaging with other researchers and societal actors beyond the scientific community, or dialogue with other knowledge systems, been incorporated in the career evaluation and progression systems or are foreseen by the end of 2025? (*ref.: (v) [20.a](#), [20.c](#), [20.d](#)*)

YES / NO

If yes, please provide details and links as relevant.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPo

In order to be taken into account for researchers' evaluations, career advancement, internal job applications or Belspo research project funding, research results financed by Belspo have to be deposited (access to the content is optional) in the applicants' RPO's institutional Open Access repository or in Orfeo. In cases of noncompliance with the Belspo APC, embargo, licence and copyright policies, concerned publications will not be taken into account.

WEWIS

Some universities and research performing institutions are also encouraging researchers to also explicitly mention their efforts that go beyond the 'classical academic achievements' in order to make their case for promotions, for instance to get appointed/promoted as a professor.

The evaluation of the Open Science policy plan in Flanders shows that extra attention for rewarding OS efforts should be considered in the next policy period.

FWB

The Board of Trustees of the F.R.S.-FNRS has approved the initiative consisting of valorizing the researchers' open science practices in the frame of its evaluation procedures.

- 5.3 Have there been any initiatives in your country to recognize and reward open science practices or are they foreseen by the end of 2025? (*ref.: (v) [20.a](#), [20.b](#), [20.c](#), [20.e](#), [20.f](#), [20.g](#), [20h](#)*)

YES / NO

If yes, for each initiative, please provide more information, including on the stakeholders^{xi} that are involved or lead the initiative, and links as relevant.

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

WEWIS

Yes. The governance of the Open Science policy plan in Flanders entails several thematic working groups and project groups. Recently, the project group “Enriching Research Assessment with Open Science Practices” concluded its work, by formulating concrete recommendations, approved by all stakeholders via the Flemish Open Science Board (FOSB). Concrete steps are now taken to further include aspects of Open Science, Open Data and FAIR in the assessment of research projects by FWO.

Efforts spent by researchers on Open Science can be reported to FWO already for some time, among other non-classically academic output/efforts, in line with the evolutions of CoARA at international/European level.

Some universities and research performing institutions are also encouraging researchers to also explicitly mention their efforts that go beyond the ‘classical academic achievements’ in order to make their case for promotions, for instance to get appointed/promoted as a professor.

The evaluation of the Open Science policy plan in Flanders shows that extra attention for rewarding OS efforts should be considered in the next policy period.

FWB

The Board of Trustees of the F.R.S.-FNRS has approved the initiative consisting of valorizing the researchers' open science practices in the frame of its evaluation procedures.

- 5.4 Have there been any unintended negative consequences^{xii} of open science practices reported in your country? (ref.: [\(v\) 20](#))

YES ~~/NO~~

If **yes**, please provide more information and specify if there is a strategy or plan to preventing and mitigating such consequences.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSP0

No.

WEWIS

The evaluation of the Open Science policy plan 2019-2024 in Flanders has shown that the reporting on the KPI's included in the policy plan entails a large administrative burden, especially for smaller institutions. In view of the next policy period, this is considered as an important point of attention. Additionally, we are constantly working with stakeholders to improve the flow of information to our FRIS system, as this has the potential to further automate a lot of the reporting and monitoring requirements.

Furthermore, the evaluation showed that at times, researchers experience conflicting expectations between Open Science and valorisation.

The full evaluation report can be found via [the WEWIS website:](https://www.ewi-vlaanderen.be/sites/default/files/2025-01/Evaluatie%20-%20Open%20Science-beleid%20-%20rapport%20-%202024.pdf)
<https://www.ewi-vlaanderen.be/sites/default/files/2025-01/Evaluatie%20-%20Open%20Science-beleid%20-%20rapport%20-%202024.pdf>

FWB

The monitoring reports on the 2018 open access decree tend to show an increase in APCs.

6. PROMOTING INNOVATIVE APPROACHES FOR OPEN SCIENCE AT DIFFERENT STAGES OF THE SCIENTIFIC PROCESS

6.1 Have there been any initiatives at the national or institutional level that promote innovative, participatory methodological or procedural changes at different stages of the research cycle to increase the openness of the entire scientific process? (*ref.:* [\(vi\) 21](#))

~~YES, at the national level.~~

~~YES, at the institutional level.~~

YES, at both national and institutional levels.

~~NO~~

If yes, please indicate which of the recommended actions they address and provide more information and links as relevant:

- promotion of pre-prints
- exploration of open peer-review practices
- valuing and sharing of negative scientific results and associated data
- participatory methods that value inputs from societal actors, e.g. citizen science, crowdsourcing scientific projects
- development of participatory strategies for identifying the needs of marginalized communities and highlighting socially relevant issues to be incorporated into research agendas.
- promoting open innovation practices.
- Others (with a box to add text)

If no, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSP0

Initiatives at federal level (Africa Museum):

- Public citizen science webinars for researchers
- Citizen Science for and with schools, 15.03.2024, [recording](#)
- History and heritage, a feminist exploration, 25.04.2024, [recording](#)
- Internal citizen science seminars and workshops

“Working with volunteers in citizen science” internal workshop for curators, AfricaMuseum, 04.2024

“How to design engagement in citizen science” internal workshop for the biology department, AfricaMuseum, 27.06.2024

“What’s cooking in citizen science at the AfricaMuseum” annual internal seminar and exchange event for researchers and citizen scientists, AfricaMuseum, 10.12.2024

“Citizen Science and heritage” inspiration and network day, Lamot, Mechelen, 12.09.2024.

On September 12, Scivil, the Flemish knowledge center on citizen science, organized a Citizen Science Inspiration and Networking Day which took place at Lamot in Mechelen. The networking day was organized in collaboration with FARO, Histories, and the AfricaMuseum. We had the pleasure of welcoming over 200 citizen science enthusiasts, researchers, citizen scientists, museum workers, policy makers and non-profit organizations. This edition put an extra spotlight on the heritage sector.

WEWIS

WEWIS funds the Flemish knowledge center on citizen science which supports researchers in performing citizen science projects.

<https://www.scivil.be/en>

Furthermore, there is the AMAI! initiative which is dedicated to setting up citizen science projects specifically linked to AI.

[amai!](#)

All or almost all research performing institutions have various projects where they actively engage citizens.

At institutional / individual researcher level, the practice of publishing preprints and open peer review has been discussed during Open Science events. There are big differences on these practices between disciplines. It is not a prominent thematic in the institutions' open science policies, but is considered by various researchers nonetheless.

Valuing and sharing of negative scientific results and associated data is a topic that has been suggested throughout the evaluation of the Flemish Open Science policy, and is something that is considered during the discussions on the next Open Science policy, as we notice an interest from the researchers on this topic.

In terms of Open Innovation, VLAIO supports living labs and also enables the universities of applied sciences and arts to engage with companies via the Blikopener initiative.

<https://www.vlaio.be/nl/subsidies-financiering/living-labs-circulaire-economie>

<https://www.vlaamsehogescholeerraad.be/nl/blikopener>

7. PROMOTING INTERNATIONAL AND MULTI-STAKEHOLDER COOPERATION IN THE CONTEXT OF OPEN SCIENCE AND WITH VIEW TO REDUCING DIGITAL, TECHNOLOGICAL AND KNOWLEDGE GAPS

7.1 How is your country promoting and facilitating international scientific collaborations on open science as outlined in the 2021 Recommendation on Open Science? (ref.: [\(vii\) 22.a](#))

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPO

BELSPO is a board member of [CONOSC](#). The Council for National Open Science Coordination (CoNOSC) is a network of national Open Science coordinators in the UN-European region.

Furthermore, BELSPO is National Point of Reference (NPR) for Open Access (expert group of the EU Commission)

WEWIS

WEWIS provides the Belgian Delegate in the EOSC Steering Board.

All Belgian policy levels have the possibility to discuss together via a recurring intra-Belgian meeting.

Several Belgian research institutions are a member of the EOSC-Association. Belnet (federal level) facilitates recurring meetings with these stakeholders.

In general, in all our research and innovation policies, we encourage our stakeholders to seek international collaborations.

- 7.2 Does your country have a strategy or a plan for stimulating cross-border multi-stakeholder collaboration on open science, including with regards to exchange of best practices, capacity building and metrics for open science? (ref.: [\(vii\) 22.b, 22.e, 22.f](#))

~~YES~~ / NO

If **yes**, please provide links as relevant and more information.

If **no**, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

WEWIS

There is no dedicated strategy, but via delegation in EOSC and interaction on this with stakeholders this is achieved. We also provide co-funding opportunities for European projects.

Many institutions do work together on open science internationally, for instance via consortia to build up thematic repositories. E.g. <https://ilvo.vlaanderen.be/en/research-projects/naar-een-open-acces-dataplatform-om-samen-te-werken-aan-bodemgezondheid>, [Dissco Flanders](#)

- 7.3 Is your country involved in any discussion on the establishment of regional and international funding mechanisms for open science? (ref.: [\(vii\) 22.c](#))

YES / NO

If **yes**, please provide links as relevant and more information.

If **no**, please, if possible, briefly explain the reason and the difficulties or obstacles in this area and indicate if there are plans to do so.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSPO

We have our own funding mechanisms for open science at Belgian federal level.

WEWIS

Funding mechanism for open science currently exists. Via Open Science Policy plan in Flanders, and via FWO – where costs for Open Science can also be submitted for projects. And contributing Open Science is a condition in almost all our public funding agreements with research institutions.

INNOVIRIS

Funding mechanisms exist. We mentioned the two most important: Brussels Studies and Brussels Studies Institute (BRIO).

8. GENERAL CONSIDERATIONS

8.1 Are there any specific external causes that may impede the implementation of the 2021 UNESCO Recommendation on Open Science in your country?

YES/~~NO~~

If yes, please provide more information.

Individual responses of different policy levels

BELSP0

The rising attention to knowledge security may lead to more caution in the implementation of (not only) UNESCO recommendations in Open Science. There is certainly complementarity between OS and Knowledge security, but it is important that related policies can be considered in a holistic perspective.

WEWIS

In Flanders/Belgium, as in the rest of the EU, it is considered important that the UNESCO recommendation is implemented in synergy with the European evolutions, and to avoid duplication of efforts in terms of reporting and monitoring on all these different levels.

Knowledge security can be seen as impeding the implementation of Open Science, but also as an opportunity to incorporate Open Science in a smart manner in every step of the research process and policy, hand in hand with knowledge security. In our opinion, Open Science and specifically FAIR data and good RDM, can be precisely what is needed to be better equipped to deal with certain aspects of knowledge security.

Discussions on the complementarity are of course continuously evolving.

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- i Please refer to the elements of open science defined in the 2021 Recommendation, namely : [open scientific knowledge](#) (including open access to scientific publications, research data, open educational resources, open-source software and code, open hardware), [open science infrastructures](#), [open engagement of societal actors](#) and [open dialogue with other knowledge systems](#).
 - ii The 2021 Recommendation outlines a set of shared values of open science stemming from the rights-based, ethical, epistemological, economic, legal, political, social, multi-stakeholder and technological implications of opening science to society and broadening the principles of openness to the whole cycle of scientific research. It also provides a set of guiding principles, as a framework for enabling conditions and practices, which uphold the values of open science and can realize the ideals of open science.
Please see the [values of open science](#), namely quality and integrity, collective benefit, equity and fairness, and diversity and inclusiveness.
Please see the [guiding principles for open science](#), namely transparency, scrutiny, critique and reproducibility; equality of opportunities; responsibility, respect and accountability; collaboration, participation and inclusion; flexibility and sustainability.
 - iii National STI policy is most commonly a governmental document developed by governing bodies leading the STI policy design and implementation in a given country, which formulates objectives and guides actions and decision-making processes in the area of STI on the national level.
 - iv These can include specific national policies, sets of guidelines, rules, regulations, laws, principles, or directions to govern open science practices.
 - v Policy instruments include programmes, methods and mechanisms of technical and operational nature, required to solve the issues set by the policy, with focus on the target beneficiaries, resources, indicators, and set of goals for delivering products (short term), results (medium-term), and impacts (long term).
 - vi A funding mechanism refers to a policy instrument or process through which financial resources are allocated or provided for a specific purpose. Some examples are block funding, research grants, support for technological poles and centres of excellence, support for science parks and innovation centres, Infrastructure grants (for research facilities, labs, instruments), communication and outreach funds, innovation funds, loans and tax credits scholarships, studentships, fellowships, trust funds, sectoral funds.
 - vii Examples can include sharing open scientific knowledge (publications, research data, educational resources, software and hardware) with other scientists and with the public, sharing or using open infrastructures, collaboration with other researchers, with national and local societal actors such as policy makers, or sectors such as industry, agriculture, and health, and collaboration and open dialogue with indigenous peoples and local communities.

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- viii A national research and education network (NREN) is a specialised internet service provider dedicated to supporting the needs of the research and education communities within a country.
- ix Some examples of open science infrastructures include major shared scientific equipment or sets of instruments, open computational and data manipulation service infrastructures that enable collaborative and multidisciplinary data analysis, open science platforms and repositories for publications, research data and source codes, archives, open bibliometrics and scientometrics systems for assessing and analysing scientific domains, open laboratories, software forges and virtual research environments, open innovation testbeds, incubators, science museums, science parks and infrastructure for non-digital materials.
- x Open Educational Resources are learning, teaching and research materials in any format and medium that reside in the public domain or are under copyright that have been released under an open license, that permit no-cost access, re-use, re-purpose, adaptation and redistribution by others ([2019 Recommendation on Open Educational Resources](#))
- xi For example, research funders, universities, research institutions, learned societies, scientific publishers and journal editorial boards.
- xii For example, predatory behaviours, data migration, exploitation and privatization of research data, increased costs for scientists and high article processing charges associated with certain business models in scientific publishing that may be causes of inequality for the scientific communities around the world and, in some cases, the loss of intellectual property and knowledge.